FIFTEEN

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Pakistan had faced enough humiliation and was on the verge of losing the war, but was still adamant about not withdrawing its troops from Kargil, even when pressurized by the then president of the United States of America, Bill Clinton. India, on the other hand, had won one hard-earned victory after another while so many martyrs registered their respectful names in the history of the nation. Heroes emerged on the battlefield every day. In the making were exemplary stories of valour that would inspire successors for generations to come.

The war in Kargil had taught me a few lessons as well. I had understood the importance of life and what we must make of it before time ran out. I was making the best of my life while in Srinagar, learning lessons of discipline, determination, improvisation and ethics on the front line. And yet there was so much more waiting for me.

Eight pilots from my unit, including me, had stationed themselves in Srinagar since the war had begun. As the only female officer in the group, our detachment commander, who was also the flight commander, felt responsible for my well-being under his command. He would keep asking me if I needed anything and urged me to not hesitate in telling him if there was anything that made me uncomfortable. Thinking that I might get